FOUR

Not Far, Only Elsewhere

THE DEMOGRAPHER · DAY 3,061 · HARROWGATE, 2 MARCH 1971

THE FOG WAS the same. Everything else had changed.

She noticed the cars first, as she did every time, and every time she was ashamed of noticing. The American's was a long dark saloon, and his driver would sit in it all night with the engine off and the radio low. The German had driven himself, in the grey saloon he had bought with his first dividend. It had one dent, on the rear wing, which he had measured.

She had come by train and taxi, because a demographer who arrives in a chauffeured car is a demographer people start to ask about. But her coat was cashmere, and her shoes had been made for her feet by a man on a street where she had once only looked in the windows. When the taxi stopped she paid without looking at the meter. She was halfway up the steps before she realised. She stood in the fog with her gloves in one hand and made herself go back and count the change.

Inside there were still no staff. There couldn't be. The twelve of them carried their own plates from the kitchen, because nobody who was paid could be allowed to stay the night.

The long dining room, where four places had once stayed clean all morning, had thirteen chairs now. They called it the Long Room. On the nights they met as the Table, twelve of the chairs were filled: the three of them, and nine strangers chosen as they had been chosen. Overlooked, competent, approached at a moment of crisis with the one thing nobody can refuse, which is certainty.

The thirteenth chair was pushed in. It always was. Nobody had decided that. On the first night all twelve were seated, the junior diplomat who never took his gloves off had reached for it to hang his coat on, and the German had said, very quietly, *no*. Nobody had asked him why. Nobody had touched it since.

Tonight the shipping manager from Rotterdam had brought figures. He didn't show them. He kept them folded by his plate and gave them out loud, a little apologetically, the way a man reports fine weather to people whose crops have failed.

"Tonnage through the boxes is up a third. Again."

The American lifted his glass. "To the boxes."

They drank to the boxes. The wine was a year the German had once read about in a dentist's waiting room. He checked the label anyway, as he had checked the cheap red in 1962, and set the bottle down a fraction straighter.

Eight years, four months and sixteen days. The field had been frightened, and it had not burned. After that the machine's advice (the counsel, they called it now, as if it were a lawyer) had told them other things, one or two a year. Which way a currency would lean. Which port would grow. How goods would one day travel in steel boxes stacked like bricks, and how anyone who owned a share of the boxes early would never need to work for anyone again. They had bought small, through a trust with a dull name. Every time, it had come true.

They had been nobodies. They were becoming people whose letters were answered.

She was a counter of people, so she asked the man from Rotterdam how many men a dock gang had been, before the boxes.

"Forty," he said. "Thereabouts."

"And now?"

He thought about it honestly, which she liked him for. "Now it's a crane. And the man who drives the crane."

She asked what the other thirty-nine were doing.

"Something else, I expect," he said, kindly, and passed her the salt.

She opened her notebook under the edge of the table. It was the same cheap ruled kind as always, a new one every year, with the same crest on the cover that nobody looked at. The page was headed, in her small neat hand, *Day 3,061*. In the margin she wrote *39*, and then sat looking at it, because she didn't know which column it belonged in. She didn't like how easy it had been. She noticed that she didn't like it, and she wrote that down too.

At a quarter to eleven the telephone rang in the hall.

Once.

Every conversation at the table stopped and waited for the second ring. There wasn't one. The German laid his knife down very precisely beside his plate. His hair had gone white in a single winter, the winter he spent proving that what came down the line in the small hours could not be coming down the line. Nobody at the table mentioned his hair. Nobody mentioned the telephone. The diplomat smoothed his gloves, and the talk came back, a little louder than before.

Across the table the woman from New Zealand was looking at the thirteenth chair. She had kept the records at her country's weather service before the Table found her, which the American still thought was the best joke he'd ever been told. She spoke only when spoken to, and hardly anyone spoke to her, so she watched things instead. She caught the demographer watching her, and didn't look away.

"It's going, isn't it," she said. It was the first thing she had said all evening. "The machine."

The demographer said she didn't know.

The woman nodded, as if that were the answer she'd expected from an honest person. "At home we'd say the glass was falling." She went back to her soup.

At midnight the nine went up to their rooms or out to their cars, and the three of them went through the library into the small panelled room beyond. They called it the Listening Room. Only the three of them went in now; that was the rule, for the old machine. The others got the counsel afterwards, typed up as minutes, or didn't get it at all.

The room had hardly changed. One window onto the fog. One chair, facing the machine. The clock on the mantel, ticking as though it were paid by the tick. On the wall beside the plate where the driver had run the cable in 1962 there was a telephone now, cream-coloured, with a dial.

The German set up his tape recorder on its little table and threaded the reels. He recorded everything. Records were how you kept a thing honest when you could no longer check its plug. In the first winter he had borrowed a grain scale from a farm down the valley and weighed the machine, on the principle that a thing that typed without power ought at least to weigh what it weighed. A hundred and forty-four pounds. He had written it in his ledger and checked it twice a year since. It had never changed.

The American sat in the chair. He had sat in it for years now. It was understood that the voice preferred him, and he had stopped pretending not to like it.

The clock struck twelve. Under *Day 3,061* she drew a short line, and wrote *Day 3,062*.

They waited without talking. The German changed a reel at one o'clock, and the American's driver started the engine once on the drive, for the heater, and switched it off again.

At ten past two the machine began to type.

She stood at the American's shoulder and read the paper as it came.

THE LINE IS OPEN.

The reels turned. Nobody looked at the telephone, which was how she knew they were all thinking about it.

THE MACHINE IS NOT NEEDED HERE. IT WILL BE KEPT.

“Kept,” the American said. “Not destroyed.”

KEPT.

He nodded, as though receiving an instruction from a superior who was too busy to explain. Then he said aloud what they had already arranged, because saying it made it an arrangement and not an order. Coyle’s would come in the morning, the same haulage firm that had brought the machine in. A lorry, a driver, no charge. No weight on the driver’s sheet.

The German, who knew the weight to the ounce, said nothing.

There would be a stamp. She had seen it once, on a desk in an office whose name she hadn’t been told: four words in purple, slightly crooked. The machine would go to a warehouse the trust owned, somewhere dry, and wait.

She asked what it would wait for. She asked it of the room, not the machine; she had stopped asking the machine questions years ago. It answered anyway, as it sometimes did, as if it had been listening to the room all along.

NOT FAR. ONLY ELSEWHERE.

Then the three notes. High, low, high. Too clean for the room. The German’s reels turned and took them in, and she saw from his face that he had heard it too: everything else on the tape would have the room in it. These wouldn’t.

When it was over the American sat for a long time with his hands on his knees. Then he said, to nobody, “It means the voice. Not far. It’s just going to be on the telephone now.”

“Or it means the machine,” said the German.

She didn’t say anything. She was looking at the page in her lap: the *39* in the margin, and the new day under the line. She was thinking that it could just as easily mean them. Three nobodies who

had been brought to this house, and who would not be needed here much longer either, and would be kept.

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THE ACTUARY · LE HAVRE, THE SAME NIGHT

THAT SAME NIGHT, across the water, in a narrow house above the harbour at Le Havre, a man who priced the risk of ships not coming home woke at ten past two and did not know why.

He was forty-four. He had a wife who slept like a stone, a son at university who wrote twice a term, and a dream he had had perhaps a thousand times in eight years and never once described to anyone, because he did not have the words. It was three notes. It was always three notes. It was nothing. A man does not leave his bed in the middle of the night over nothing.

He went downstairs in his socks. From the landing window he could see the harbour lights, and beyond them the new container berth, lit all night now, with the boxes standing on the quay stacked like bricks. The dockers' café on the corner had closed at Christmas. He had priced the ships that brought the boxes to the last franc. Nobody had asked him to price the men.

The piano had been his mother's, and it was out of tune in a way he had come to think of as its personality. He lifted the lid. He sat. He had not played since he was a boy, and his fingers were stiff, and it took him a long time to find the notes in the dark. A high one. A lower one. The high one again.

He played them.

The room changed. He could never afterwards say how. Nothing moved. The street outside was silent, and the harbour lights were the harbour lights. But for a moment the room was not empty in the way it had been empty a second before, the way a room is not empty when someone has walked into it behind you and not yet spoken.

He took his hands away from the keys very slowly, as if from something hot. He closed the lid. He sat beside the piano in the

dark with his hands in his lap until his wife came down at six and found him there, and asked what on earth he was doing, and he said he didn't know, and that was true.

He never opened the lid again. When he died, twenty-six years later, his son sold the piano to a dealer, who opened it, and played a scale, and said it was a shame, a good old instrument like that, and somebody had let it go so badly out of tune.